Repetition Over Resolution: Loop-Based Electronic Film Scores and Atemporal Cinema

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1. Introduction

In classical Hollywood cinema, music is composed with the intention of supporting narrative development and guiding the viewer's emotional journey to reinforce a clear sense of progression from beginning to end (Gorbman, 1987). Since the 1990s, however, a distinct strand of contemporary cinema has broken from the assumption that narrative must progress toward a resolution. These films occupy what Todd McGowan identifies as an atemporal mode of cinema in his 2011 book, *Out of Time.* Where classical narrative is oriented around the pursuit of an object that promises resolution (what McGowan terms 'desire'), atemporal cinema is oriented around the 'drive,' a concept describing a character's compulsion to repeat an encounter with loss rather than overcome it. His framework is grounded in editing and narrative structure; but where he does acknowledge sound, it is not described as a primary source of atemporal experience in its own right.

This paper specifically looks at loop-based electronic scoring to argue that film music can function as its own structural mechanism for producing atemporality. It will analyze three distinct ways through which this type of film music shifts from a supporting role to a determining one by using *Climax* (2018), *Challengers* (2024), and *The Moment* (2026) as case studies.

2.1. Classical Scoring and Narrative Time

In *Unheard Melodies* (1987), Claudia Gorbman argues that film music, in the classical Hollywood model, is intended to remain unnoticed in service of the narrative. Of her seven principles governing classical scoring, three are most relevant here: inaudibility, continuity, and narrative cueing. These principles are best understood not as strict rules, but as a consistent system that explains how music serves the story.

Gorbman's principle of inaudibility holds that film music should not demand attention. Its purpose is to not be consciously heard, but to sit beneath the surface of the scene in subordination to dialogue and image. A score that intrudes on the spectator's awareness risks breaking their immersion in the narrative world. When music stays beneath that threshold, the spectator is not listening to a composition but experiencing the story's reality. This state of immersion is what allows the score to perform its next function: continuity.

Film music is made inaudible in service of continuity; to cover the cuts and transitions so they do not disrupt the illusion of forward movement for the viewer. Every edit in a film is technically a fracture that threatens to pull the viewer out of the story, whether it’s a jump between camera angles or a change in setting between scenes. However, music works across these breaks to establish a consistent sense of rhythm that keeps the viewer within the current of a progressing timeline. According to this framework, the score cannot set its own pace because its rhythm must follow the dramatic action on screen. If a scene transitions from a high action moment to a quiet conversation, the music must modulate to keep up with the change in emotional register. By surrendering its rhythm to these narrative needs, the score ensures it remains "unheard" precisely

because it moves in sync with the story's cadence. The narrative provides the map and the music simply follows it.

Both of these principles support a third: narrative cueing, in which the score actively orients the spectator within the story by responding to its emotional and dramatic signals. Gorbman divides narrative cueing into two functions: referential and connotative. Referential cuing anchors the viewer in the story's geography and interpersonal relationships; this might be a recurring theme that tells you who might arrive on screen, or where you are in the narrative. The connotative type refers to cues that use tone and harmony to tell you how to feel; signaling feelings like danger or romance before the image makes it explicit. Together, these cues indicate that the score is always pointing somewhere in the future. Further, by telling the viewer how to feel about what they are seeing, music actively reinforces the feeling of each moment being a necessary step toward that future resolution.

Classical scoring, in other words, is fundamentally oriented toward an ending, promising the viewer that the film is a purposeful journey moving through time toward an end. The score participates in the film's forward progression, only ever going somewhere because the story is already going there. It is precisely this format that loop-based electronic scoring avoids.

2.2. Loop-Based Electronic Scoring and Atemporality

Classical scores do repeat, but when a theme recurs it is always purposive; it returns as a chronological anchor that develops or concludes to reinforce a sense of arrival or closure by informing the viewer of where they've been and how close they are to the end. However, the fundamental characteristic of a musical loop is its refusal of development. Where a classical

theme moves through time to signal a destination, a loop circulates within it. It does not provide a sense of where the viewer has been or where they are going; but instead, it anchors them in a persistent ‘now’ that offers no signal of an approaching resolution.

As the basic unit of electronic music, a loop repeats. Short phrases cycle back to their starting points without advancing somewhere new. This is not a deficiency of the form but its organizing logic. The dancers inside a rave are not waiting for the music to arrive anywhere and that is the point. The experience is not one of desire to reach an endpoint, but of drive; the compulsion to remain inside the repetition itself. This is precisely the temporal logic McGowan identifies in atemporal cinema. Electronic music is designed to sustain a single state rather than move through it, so when it’s brought into the theater, the temporal assumptions it brings reorganize the viewer’s experience. Compared to the classical model, which designates the score as a "narrator" guiding the viewer through the story from a safe distance, loop-based scores destroy this distance. By refusing to gesture toward a future resolution, loop-based electronic scoring disorients the viewer’s sense of temporal progression while the narrative continues to unfold; which, at times, draws the viewer closer to the characters’ experience of time. To better understand how this temporal logic works in practice, we will look at three specific films in which loop-based scoring shapes the viewer’s experience of time.

3. Physical Entrapment in *Climax*

Gaspar Noé's *Climax* (2018) follows a French dance troupe whose celebration spirals into paranoia and violence after someone spikes the sangria with LSD.[1] The film’s soundtrack is built

[1] *Climax* is available for rent on Amazon Prime Video.

from existing electronic tracks and because this music was originally made for the dancefloor, they inherit no cinematic cues and owe nothing to the narrative they are placed against. The film establishes this early. A five-minute single-take dance sequence[2] set to Cerrone's "Supernature" directly follows the opening interviews that introduce the characters. The beat serves the dancers by allowing them to show off their skill, and the characters agree to its terms by moving to it. The music feels almost inaudible at this point in the Gorbman sense, because its presence makes sense here: dancers are dancing to music. This resembles McGowan's concept of desire: the music and the characters are oriented toward the same goal.

This rhythmic contract does not end when the choreography finishes. The troupe's DJ, Daddy, continues mixing the tracks into a continuous set. During this stretch, the music recedes into an ambient pulse that sustains the party atmosphere. This is inaudible in the Gorbman sense because the characters are still in control of their environment, and this familiarity lulls the viewer into a false sense of security. The loop is already surrounding the characters, but because they are still in control as they drink and socialize, the repetition feels like a natural feature of the environment rather than a threat. Noé signals the contract breaking with the arrival of the film's title card, which is set to Thomas Bangalter's "What To Do" and does not appear until forty-two minutes in. The loop that was once a tool for the dancers is now running the film. As the LSD takes hold and the characters descend into paranoia, the same needle-drops keep coming, but their function changes. The mix does not pivot so much as escalate, getting more aggressive while remaining structurally the same.

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[2] *Climax*, directed by Gaspar Noe (2018), scene "Supernature"

The music intensifies its own internal rules by not responding to any of the atrocities on screen as the characters are consumed by paranoia and turn on one another. This use of sound to create a sensory overload marks the group's progression from complete chaos to utter nightmare; and the shift is most visible during Lou's violent psychological breakdown.[3] As Daft Punk's "Rollin' and Scratchin'" takes control of the next seven minutes, Lou is cornered and pushed into self-mutilation by a group of paranoid peers. Despite the extreme escalation in violence on-screen, the song's metallic screeches and heavy kicks are unwavering. When the protagonist (Selva) tries to flee the scene, she finds herself lost in a maze of dark and endless hallways. The sonic assault continues without end and she quickly loses any sense of where she is, effectively becoming trapped in an agonizing present where she can not find an exit or understand what is happening to her.

In Chion's terms, this use of sound is paradoxically both empathetic and anempathetic. While the industrial noise serves as a mirror for the characters' intoxication, the music is hostile and remains indifferent to their internal experience. This indifference eventually transforms into an active suffocation that crowds out everything else and violates the bounds of inaudibility. Visually, the viewer moves within the terror across various unbroken takes. Sonically, they are held captive as they watch a nightmare around them. The abrasive sounds become the moving parts of a cold machine that holds you in place, while the narrative struggles to make substantial movement toward a resolution to collapse twelve hours into one long inescapable moment. Without any sonic cues to indicate that time is passing or that an end is approaching, the soundtrack marks the total collapse of the film's temporal progression. It effectively replaces

[3] *Climax,* directed by Gaspar Noe (2018), scene "Rollin' and Scratchin'"

narrative time with its own changing tempo, thus producing the atemporal condition McGowan describes without relying on editing alone.

4. Structural Reorganization in *Challengers*

Where *Climax* uses pre-existing needle drops to trap its characters in the violent present, Luca Guadagnino's *Challengers* (2024) utilizes a commissioned score by Nine Inch Nails's Trent Reznor and Atticus Ross to produce a different kind of atemporality. The film revolves around a nonlinear love triangle across thirteen years of professional tennis; its timeline structured around a 2019 match that serves as both the film's opening and its conclusion.[4] The circular timeline jumps, primarily, between three time periods across those thirteen years. However, Reznor and Ross refuse to differentiate these time periods, instead opting for a relentless techno heartbeat that flattens the timeline. By avoiding chronological markers in the score, the film renders the events of 2006 and 2019 somewhat sonically indistinguishable, denying the viewer of the comfort of temporal distance.

This is a radical departure from Gorbman's principle of narrative cueing: music is not used to indicate changes in time and place through tonal shifts or period-specific instrumentation so that the viewer is aware of whether they are in the past or the present, nor does it guide their emotional response. This score intentionally abandons both referential and connotative cuing to obscure these details from the viewer. This temporal flattening is best illustrated by how the main theme bookends the central 2019 match. During the opening sequence, the film establishes its high-tempo pace with the theme ("Challengers").[5] The narrative is then interjected with a series

[4] *Challengers* is available to stream on Hulu.
[5] *Challengers,* directed by Luca Guadagnino (2024), scene "Introduction"

of flashbacks that navigates the thirteen years of history leading up to this scene, repeatedly returning to it before finally arriving at its conclusion. On that final return, the theme plays in an extended form: "Challengers: Match Point."[6] Having the same track both open and close the film suggests that the characters' interpersonal relationships have remained emotionally static throughout those thirteen years of history. While we can visually see the difference in the characters' ages, the sound insists that they are still stuck in the same unresolved dynamic. Thus, the rivalry is not a journey moving toward a destination, but a repeating state of desire that folds the beginning and the present into the same moment. In McGowan's terms, the return of the theme is the sonic manifestation of the drive: the rivalry progresses not out of desire for a future resolution, but as a compulsion to keep returning to the same unresolved tension.

Reznor and Ross collaborated with Boys Noize to release *Challengers [Mixed]*, a twenty-eight minute continuous mixed version of the score (Miller, 2024). By presenting a version of the film's music that's stripped of narrative context, Reznor and Ross reveal that the score was never truly subordinate to the film. Because the music's internal logic is autonomous and circular, the score does not move the narrative forward toward a winner, but simply resets the rivalry to its baseline tension. The film suddenly ends before we can see a winner crowned, leaving the match frozen at the moment of maximum tension. Without a traditional narrative resolution, the film deceptively leaves itself in a permanent loop. The result is an atemporal stasis where the desire for a winner is entirely replaced by the drive of the match itself.

[6] *Challengers,* directed by Luca Guadagnino (2024), scene "Match Point"

5. Systematic Stasis in *The Moment*

Aidan Zamiri's *The Moment*[7] (2026) is a mockumentary following a fictionalized Charli XCX as she navigates a music industry that needs her but has no regard for her wants or needs. Her label pushes her to extend the *Brat* era through brand deals, and more specifically, a sponsored Amazon Music concert film that denigrates what began as a personal artistic moment into a commercial product designed to be sustained indefinitely. A.G. Cook's score exists entirely separate from her voice so that it can exist only on screen while the music plays independently as a representation of the industry's ruthless nature; rather than her internal journey. Moving unpredictably between distorted basslines and sudden moments of near silence, the score refuses to anchor the narrative in a consistent rhythm, leaving the viewer unable to recognize they're stuck in a permanent, marketable present.

The film's satirical tone is also inseparable from the way it uses sound. When Charli records an emotional voicemail for her creative director, she admits that she's grown tired of *Brat* and realizes submitting to the label's wishes is her only way of putting an end to the era.[8] Yet, the score still refuses to acknowledge her internal experience at that moment. She tries to move forward, but the music will not move with her, and if this were a classical score, that refusal might be considered a form of failure. Here, it functions as the argument, the music is not indifferent, it is actively resisting: repeatedly declaring the era isn't yet over, and as long as the music keeps playing, it isn't. Atemporality works systematically here, trapping a cultural moment as a commercial era that the industry refuses to surrender to the past. The film's final

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[7] *The Moment* is available for rent on Amazon Prime Video

[8] *The Moment,* directed by Aidan Zamiri (2026), scene "Voicemail to Celeste"

image is not Charli moving on, but a bubbly trailer for the bastardized concert film, *Brat Live!*[9] Once the credits roll, Cook's "Dread" plays and her voice appears for the first time in the original score; yet, only as a distorted, biological residue left behind by the machinery that once rejected her but has now digested her entirely, continuing the loop past the end of the movie because ending it would mean the moment is over, and if the moment ends, there is nothing left to sell.

6. Conclusion

The three films examined in this paper illustrate how loop-based electronic scoring functions as more than just a stylistic choice or signifier of cultural edge. Directors are increasingly choosing electronic loops over orchestral arcs because the former offers something that the latter structurally cannot. In *Climax*, the elemental indifference of the needle-drops became the film's mechanism of entrapment. In *Challengers*, a commissioned score built around unresolvable loops flattens thirteen years of rivalry into an endless cycle of tension. In *The Moment*, techno loops become the instrument of an industry that refuses to let a cultural moment become the past. Each film employs sound in a different way while still fitting into the condition McGowan describes as central to atemporal cinema; time is not organized around the desire for resolution, but around the compulsion to repeat.

[9] *The Moment,* directed by Aidan Zamiri (2026), scene *"Brat Live!"*

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